

a gift to German gunners on the ground. The relief was palpable when the crew felt the bomber lift upward as the weight of the bombs dropped away – and then there was the small question of getting home. Many of the B-17s would by then be carrying significant damage; some would have dead or wounded aircrew on board. The hours would seem long before, in midafternoon, the bombers returned to their airfields, counted in by anxious ground crews.

Fighter support

The only way that the effectiveness of day bombing, and the survival rate of bomber crews, could be improved was through fighter escorts to protect them from attack. But the P-38 Lightnings and P-47 Thunderbolts used as escorts in 1943,

with a range of about 450 miles (725km), there and back, could only accompany the B-17s and B-24s as far as the German border. Obviously, the Germans fighters waited until the escorts had turned away and then attacked the bombers at will. The Americans desperately needed an aircraft with a range nearer to 1,000 miles (1,600km), yet capable of holding its own in air combat with the Messerschmitts and Focke-Wulfs.

The need for a long-distance escort fighter had not been foreseen before the war and, given the long lead time involved in developing and putting into production a new aircraft, it was, on the face of it, unlikely that the need could be met. A fortuitous solution came from an unlikely quarter. The North American P-51 Mustang was a fighter aircraft that had failed. Produced in the

THE RED TAILS

REPUTEDLY THE ONLY American escort fighter group never to lose a bomber to enemy fighters was the 332nd, operating out of Italy. The 332nd Fighter Group also had another distinction: all its pilots were black. The African-American aviators only won the right to fly in combat through a hard battle against prejudice. Even after the USAAF reluctantly agreed to train them, in Tuskegee, Alabama, senior commanders stubbornly resisted sending them into combat, convinced that blacks were only suitable for use as ancillary staff. Protest and political pressure finally saw the first all-black fighter unit sent to North Africa in 1943.

The four-squadron 332nd, commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Benjamin O. Davis, assumed escort duties in mid-1944, flying on missions to well-defended targets such as Berlin and the Ploesti oilfields. Because of the color of the paint on their

99TH SQUADRON

The 99th Pursuit Squadron (whose insignia is shown right) was awarded two Presidential Unit Citations before joining the 332nd.



Mustangs, bomber pilots called them the Red Tails. The Tuskegee airmen more aggressively dubbed themselves the "Spookwaffe." In the strictly segregated US armed forces, the black pilots faced humiliating restrictions – they had to use separate R&R facilities and messes. But bomber crews soon learned that they were safer with the Red Tails than with any other escorts.

ALL-BLACK SQUADRON

Pilots of the 332nd Fighter Group pose beside one of their Mustangs in Italy in 1944. The Tuskegee airmen were credited with destroying 261 enemy aircraft, and black pilots earned 95 Distinguished Flying Crosses during the war.



United States to a British design and specification, early models performed poorly in combat and were relegated to a ground-support role. That is how it might have remained, had not a Rolls-Royce test pilot, Ron Harker, suggested replacing the Mustang's Allison engine with the Merlin used in Spitfires. Combining the American airframe with a British engine created probably the finest fighter aircraft of the war.

Equipped with drop tanks, the Mustang could fly to Berlin and back. And with a top speed of over 440mph (700kph), plus an impressive rate of climb and operational ceiling, it outclassed the Bf 109s and Fw 190s in combat performance. Introduced into the fighter-escort role from December 1943, the Mustang soon shifted the balance of the air war in favor of the American intruders, reducing bomber losses and sharply increasing the number of Luftwaffe aircraft shot down. By the spring of 1944 the USAAF was sending its bombers into Germany with up to 1,000 fighters in support.

Allied success

During 1944, the Allies won air superiority over Germany – the precondition for truly effective strategic bombing. Although the diversion of bombers to prepare for and support the D-Day

